Teenagers shaping their school journeys

How can we encourage youth aged 14–18 to participate and intervene in urban mobility solutions?

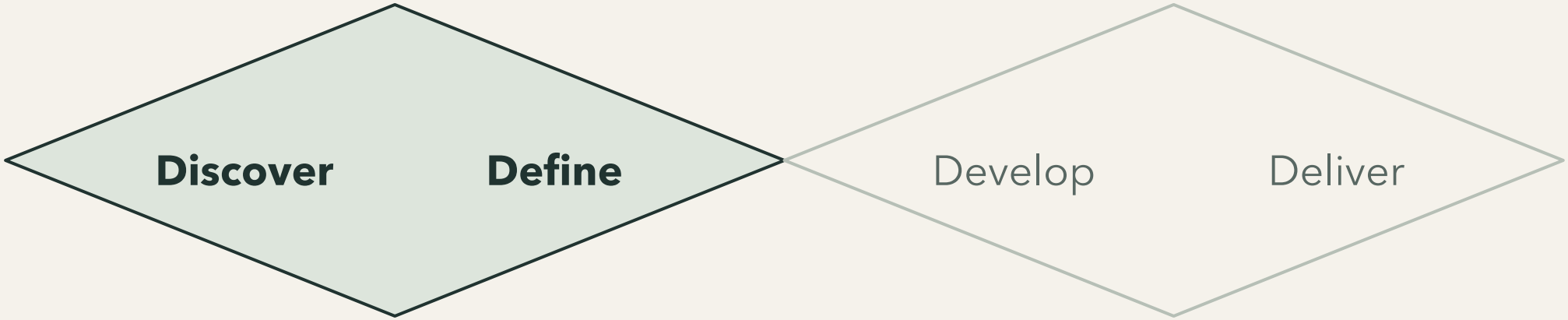
GIDT 2026/27
Instituto Superior Técnico



Participation in everyday school journeys

Working scope: ages 14–18 in Lisbon

Home-side streets, transport connections and the school gate



Current stage: understanding barriers and defining the problem

Seven interviews across different travel situations

6 teenagers

1 parent

Desk research

Semi-structured interviews

01 **Read accounts**

Journeys, workarounds and participation

02 **Group themes**

Compare constraints and counterexamples

03 **Develop insights**

Connect accounts to underlying needs

04 **Frame HMWs**

Keep possible responses open

Different journeys, different constraints

Beatriz, 17

Metro and walking

Student organiser

Exam pressure limits time

Tiago, 16

Bus and metro

Long commute and weekend work

Extra activities compete with work

Inês, 16

Wheelchair user

Bus, adapted transport and lifts

The journey and activity must both be accessible

Interest can coexist with barriers

Confidence

“I don't know how to make a proposal.”

Rodrigo, 15

Capacity

“Not like I don't want to, I can't.”

Tiago, 16

Follow-through

“If it's just for fun, I'd say yes
and then not go.”

Duarte, 17

Counterexamples within the interviews

Formal influence

"Although, ok, contradiction, the council probably has more power?"

Beatriz, 17

A visible response

"And actually they fixed it, I'd say in about two weeks."

Sofia, 46, describing a lamp repair

Mariana wants the option to travel alone. Tiago wants his bus to work.

Four barriers shape participation

Credibility	Unclear consequences can make effort feel unrewarding.	Beatriz Duarte
Capacity	Interest does not remove time, travel or access constraints.	Tiago Inês
Confidence	Everyday expertise can feel insufficient for a formal participation process.	Rodrigo Duarte
Permission	Some teenagers depend on adult trust and practical support.	Mariana Sofia

Our reframed problem

USER

Teenagers who notice school-journey problems but rarely use formal participation channels

NEED

Contribute to decisions in ways they can access and understand

BECAUSE

Everyday knowledge can coexist with doubts about influence and limits on time, access or permission

Questions for the next phase

How might we help teenagers see how their contributions influence decisions about their school journeys?

Capacity

How might we enable teenagers with limited time or difficult journeys to contribute to mobility decisions?

Confidence

How might we help teenagers turn everyday travel knowledge into contributions they feel confident making?

Permission

How might we enable teenagers who depend on adult permission or support to take part in shaping their journeys?

Which barrier should we address first?

Compare possible responses with participants.

Check timing, access and decision ownership with schools and authorities.

